of Hyderabad. KCR's 'alternative narrative', which is still in the works, has two key aspects: political and economic. At the political level, he wants all regional parties to come together to 'protect the democratic federal spirit of the country'. Meanwhile, his economic agenda is a mix of welfare and populist measures, mainly focusing on farmers and disadvantaged groups, and already tested in Telangana.

"Given his ability to comprehend and crunch numbers, propensity for doing extensive groundwork, and eloquence, KCR is a tad superior to most chief ministers of today," feels Harathi Vageeshan, who teaches political science at the NALSAR University of Law, Hyderabad. However, he is quick to add: "To have a national appeal and bring together political parties, KCR has to cultivate a national vision. In this, he appears to be inadequate."

The Telangana CM will need more than a name change to execute his party's national makeover. For one, it is tantamount to eclipsing the party's distinct regional identity—the plank on which the TRS evolved and came to power. With the state set to go the polls in 2023, over six months before the Lok Sabha election, and the two-term-old KCR government facing the anti-incumbency challenge, its leader's national ambitions seem to be a high-stakes gamble. "With the rival Congress and BJP alleging that KCR has abandoned the Telangana identity, a new claimant for this identity cannot be ruled out," cautions political commentator K. Nageshwar.

KCR's prospective fellow travellers pose the other challenge, as they too are nursing national ambitions. His Bihar counterpart and Janata Dal (United) leader Nitish Kumar was the first to mention a countrywide anti-BJP *mahagathbandhan* during KCR's visit to Patna on August 31. Then there are leaders like West Bengal CM Mamata Banerjee who too had made similar efforts ahead of the previous general election. With multiple claimants to lead a non-BJP, non-Congress alliance, the Telangana CM might soon realise that the road to Delhi is long and winding, and a tad too crowded for any smooth progress. ■

INTERVIEW

"NO QUICK SOLUTION TO THE RUSSIA UKRAINE WAR"



The United Nations has rarely been more relevant than in the contemporary world—riven by conflict and polarisation, buffeted by waves of natural disasters driven by climate change, its economy teetering on the brink of recession. In such a scenario, UN secretary general ANTONIO GUTERRES plays a crucial mediatory role. Recently in India on a two-day visit, Guterres spoke about the war in Ukraine, the fight against terrorism, possible UN Security Council reforms and more in an exclusive interview with GEETA MOHAN, the foreign affairs editor, India Today TV. Excerpts:

Q. You began your visit by paying tribute to the Mumbai terror attack victims. Yet, the UNSC is still to sanction some LeT terrorists involved in the 26/11 attacks. China has placed a technical hold for the fourth time against sanctioning a Pakistan-based terrorist.... Also, the UN is yet to define terrorism.

A. It is necessary to increase international cooperation in fighting global terrorism. Unfortunately, we do not have enough of it. When I became secretary general, my priority was to create an office of counter-terrorism. It has the capacity to foster cooperation among states, especially in training and advice on counter-terrorism policies. The problem in having a consensus over the definition of terrorism has to do with politics. But, that does not make it difficult to work together against terrorism. We cannot accept geopolitical divides to compartmentalise the issue.

Q. Is there a solution in sight to the Russia-Ukraine war? With the Russian annexation of four captured territories, has the window for negotiations closed?

A. I do not expect a quick political solution. I think both sides are convinced that they will win. For the moment, the possibility of cessation of hostilities and political negotiations is not in sight. That does not mean that people should not work for it. We in the UN have tried to seize opportunities to win trust or to address problems. After visiting President Putin and President Zelenskyy, the UN initiative managed the evacuation of